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The language of secrecy

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The shift in the use of the *ngala* and *maling* terms is often the topic of joking between friends. This is exemplified in the relationship between Folphazoi, who is a Zo member of Bobo, and Walawulu, who is Kpokawlaw's eldest son and Zo of the Baiyaemu society.⁵ Although Folphazoi is a Zo, he was, during the period of the last Poro initiations, the legal town chief. When the former chief, Bakollee Volpoi, announced his retirement and the previous chief, Vallai, did not want to resume the office, the town elders met and asked Folphazoi to take the office. Rather than merge the sacred and secular ruling structures, Folphazoi announced that he was not going to take an active part in Poro activities, while he was the chief. Folphazoi and Walawulu had joined the Poro together about thirty-five years before and since that time been close friends, a bond expressed through the *ngala-maling* joking relationship.

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When Folphazoi and Walawulu interact, they use the relationship to locate their informal rights within the setting. Although each can be *ngala* or *maling* depending on the technique of reckoning, each argues that he is the *maling* to the other. By making the other *ngala*, the speaker is entitled to take the first drink of palm wine or cane juice (raw rum) and can even take wine from the other's palm tree without permission. As the *maling*, the claimant can also jokingly abuse the other and use his status as a way of avoiding any retribution. I have recorded several hours of their ongoing speech play, especially during those occasions when one has a large gourd of palm wine to share.⁶ On the other hand, whenever there is Poro activity or official family business between their respective subcompounds of Yamii *koli*; both men take their formal structural positions without any debate. Their relationship is only problematic, and thus subject to the joking behavior, during the secular social realities.

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5. See the next section of this chapter for a discussion of this society and its relation to the other Poro bush-things or “devils.”
 6. See Kirshenblatt-Gimblett (1976) for a discussion of types of speech play in various **cultures**.

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